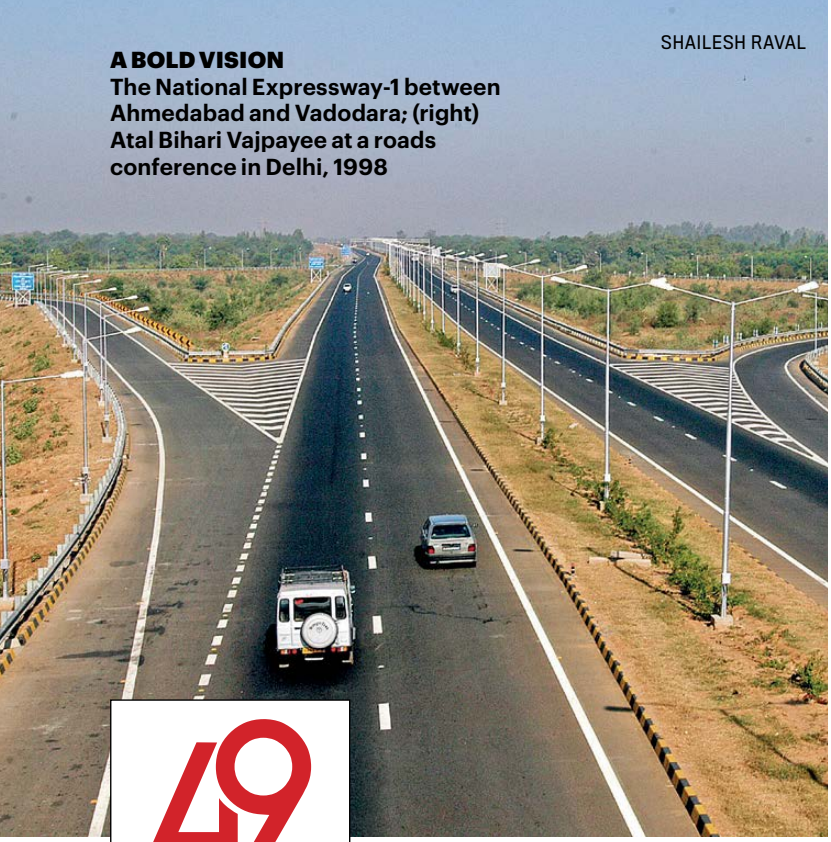


SHAILESH RAVAL



BHAWAN SINGH

A BOLD VISION
The National Expressway-1 between Ahmedabad and Vadodara; (right) Atal Bihari Vajpayee at a roads conference in Delhi, 1998

49th ANNIVERSARY

TURNING POINTS
INFRASTRUCTURE

GOLDEN QUADRILATERAL, 1999

TAKING THE HIGHWAY

Golden Quadrilateral showed how to turn a bold vision into reality. Indian highway-building leapfrogged into the future, and the scorching pace hasn't stopped since

BY AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

"*Hamare desh mein sadkon mein gaddhe hain ya gaddhon mein sadkein* (Do we have potholes on our roads, or roads in potholes)?" Fiery Opposition leader that he was, Atal Bihari Vajpayee would often ask this question by way of sharp critique of the state of India's highways. So, when he returned as prime minister in 1998—after a short-lived stint in 1996—one of the first things he did was to ask the ministry of surface transport to identify the most congested highway stretches in the country and find long-term solutions for them. The result was the Golden Quadrilateral (GQ) project, a visionary initiative launched in 1999 to connect the four metros of the country—Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai—with a 5,846-km network of four-lane highways. That ambitious plan became the foundation of the National Highways Development Project (NHDP), the largest road infrastructure initiative in modern India.

The GQ project proved to be a landmark moment for India's highways sector, teaching Indian policymakers and engineers how to execute big-ticket road contracts, raise funds, induct new engineering technology and, above all, how to actually complete proj-



"Earlier, the practice was to build small stretches. GQ was when we started taking the corridor approach in highway building...one stretch of highway as part of a larger network, covering multiple states"

— VIJAY CHHIBBER
Former Secretary, MoRTH